THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #009

MAOR SHLOMO BUILT BASE44 LARGELY ALONE, THEN SOLD IT TO WIX WITHIN MONTHS

An Israeli founder came back from reserve duty, built an AI app builder on his own, funded it himself, and was acquired for a reported $80 million. The deal is better documented than most, and it is not quite the story the headlines told.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Maor Shlomo, Founder, now at Wix
COMPANY	Base44
FOUNDED	2024 (public launch early 2025)
HQ	Israel
SECTOR	AI app builder (vibe coding)
STAGE	Acquired by Wix (June 2025)
FUNDING	None raised; sold for a reported $80m
MODEL	Subscriptions to an AI tool that builds apps from plain language

Hello again, and welcome to File #009. Thank you for reading.

In October 2023, an Israeli entrepreneur called Maor Shlomo was called up for reserve duty. He had already built and run a well-funded data company. Over the following year he served, left his job, and took a trip. And somewhere in there he had an idea for a side project that would, within a few months, become a company that Wix bought for a reported $80 million.

It is one of the best-documented stories on our list, because a listed company paid for it and has to report on what it bought. That is also why we can say, carefully, where the headline differs from the detail. (All figures are in US dollars unless we say otherwise.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Maor Shlomo, 31 at the time of the launch, previously co-founder and CEO of the data company Explorium.
- **What:** Base44, a tool that builds working apps and websites from plain-language descriptions, a category often called “vibe coding”.
- **Why it matters:** it is the cleanest recent example of a founder building an AI product alone, funding it himself, and selling it quickly, plus a rare look at what happens to such a company afterwards.
- **The number to remember:** six. That is how many employees Base44 had when Wix announced the deal, according to Calcalist, with fewer than ten in all. Wix told another outlet eight. Either way, it was never a company of one.

THE FOUNDER

Maor Shlomo is not an overnight unknown. He co-founded Explorium in 2017, at 24, and became its CEO. The company sells data tools, has more than 100 employees and has raised about $125 million, mostly from Insight Partners. He left after returning from reserve duty in late 2024.

His personal story shapes the product. After the attacks of 7 October 2023, he was called up for reserve duty and served for a long period. In one account, his unit was asked to help a nonprofit build internal tools, and the quotes for even simple software made him see how expensive it was. Calcalist describes Base44 as a side project that began during a trip after his service. He has also said publicly that he has severe ADHD, and that he built Base44 without a co-founder, an investor or a team at the start.

Some accounts say he started with about 30,000 shekels of his own money. We could not find that figure in any source, so we have left it out. What is documented is that he took no outside investment and was the company’s only shareholder.

WHAT BASE44 DOES

You describe the app you want, in ordinary language. Base44 builds it: the screens, the database, the sign-in and the hosting. It is aimed at people who aren’t developers and at developers who want a quick first version.

It came out of stealth around March 2025, and the pace was extraordinary. According to Remarkable Magazine, it passed $1 million in annualised revenue within three weeks and $1.5 million within four, with no paid marketing. Instead, Shlomo posted what he was building on LinkedIn and X. Before the sale, reports put it at over 100,000 users (Calcalist), more than 250,000 (other reports) and, in an interview, over 400,000. The counts differ because they were taken at different dates and defined differently.

WHAT "SOLO" ACTUALLY MEANT

Headlines called Base44 a solo company. At launch, it was. By the time Wix announced the deal on 18 June 2025, it had six employees, according to Calcalist, and fewer than ten people in total. Wix told another outlet eight.

The right way to read "solo" is this: for the first stretch, one person built and ran the product. He says he felt it. At a conference run by EY Israel he said "Yes, absolutely I felt lonely", and that centralised decision-making was an advantage in the early days.

He also said something that is worth copying. In an interview with Lenny Rachitsky he described competing with much bigger, better-funded rivals such as Lovable, Bolt and Replit, and said that even a solo founder is effectively managing teams, presumably meaning AI tools. The promotional material for the interview says he had not written a line of front-end code himself in the three months before the interview, and the transcript is headed around using AI to write 90 percent of his code. We could not confirm a widely repeated claim that he spent 20 to 30 percent of his time automating the business, so we have not used it.

THE NUMBERS BEFORE THE SALE

WHAT	FIGURE	SOURCE
Annualised revenue	"Multi-million dollar run rate"	Shlomo's own statement, via Calcalist
Subscription revenue	About $200,000 a month	A single report (Remarkable Magazine)
May 2025 profit	About $189,000, nearly double his own forecast	Shlomo's post, via Calcalist
Users	100,000 to 400,000, depending on the source and date	Conflicting
Outside funding	None. Shlomo was the sole shareholder	Calcalist
Staff	Six (Calcalist), eight (Wix to TechCrunch)	Conflicting

His public posts about costs and profit were part of the story. He documented the cost of the AI models that power the tool and showed that the business was profitable, which, for a company in this category, is unusual. The profit figure was reported about two weeks before the deal.

THE DEAL, READ CAREFULLY

The headline: Wix buys Base44 for $80 million.

The detail is more complicated, and it matters if you plan to quote it.

- **What was announced.** Wix said it would pay about $80 million, with additional payments through 2029 based on performance. Calcalist reported that the price could

rise if Base44 met revenue targets by 2029, without giving the targets. Wix also said it expected about $25 million of expense in 2025 for retention bonuses and equity pay for the Base44 team. That is an expense on top of the price, not a slice of it.

- **What Wix's annual report appears to show.** A search summary of Wix's 2025 annual filing with the U.S. regulator says the acquisition closed on 13 June 2025, with total consideration of about $92.2 million. According to that summary, it was made up of about $18.1 million in cash and about $74.1 million of contingent consideration, valued at the date of the deal. If that is right, most of the headline number depends on future performance, and "$80 million in cash" is not the right phrase. We could not open the note ourselves, so please read the filing before using these figures. Some coverage calls the price all cash; we could not confirm that.
- **What happened afterwards.** The earn-out is the interesting part. One report says Shlomo could receive up to an additional $90 million in cash if the milestones are met. The milestones haven't been published.

WHAT HAPPENED AFTER THE SALE

Base44 has grown, and Wix has been the one to say so.

- **November 2025:** Wix said Base44 had 2 million users, a sevenfold rise since the deal closed, and expected about $50 million in annualised recurring revenue by year-end. More than 1,000 new paying subscribers were joining each day.
- **March 2026:** Wix's results reported $100 million in annualised recurring revenue.
- **May 2026:** Wix's first-quarter results put it at about $150 million.
- **August 2026:** Wix reported the launch of Base 1, Base44's own AI model, and said it expected gross margin of about 60 percent in the second half of the year, against "near zero" at the start of 2026.

Two things stand out. The first is growth, which has far exceeded the size of the deal. The second is cost. A product that runs AI models for every build has heavy running costs, and Wix's own share price fell as it invested in marketing and infrastructure for Base44. Higher estimates of Base44's current revenue exist, including $200 million, but they come from the founder's own posts or from estimators, not from Wix's results, so we haven't used them.

WHAT YOU CAN COPY, AND WHAT YOU CAN'T

Copyable:

- **Build in public and let the product spread.** He posted progress on LinkedIn and X and reached $1 million in annualised revenue without paid marketing.
- **Move while the category is new.** The tool arrived in the first months of a wave of interest in AI app builders.

- **Automate what you can so you stay on the product.** Measure the outcome you care about, not the hours.
- **Don't raise money you don't need.** He was profitable early, which gave him options.

Not copyable:

- **Reputation.** He had already run a well-funded company and had a following, which helped the early spread.
- **Timing.** The category was brand new. It is crowded now.
- **The ending.** A large listed company with a growth problem and a strong appetite for AI paid a premium, and then paid again as the product grew. That is not a plan, it's a lucky intersection.

> **Try this**
>
> **Ask where your first thousand users could come from for free.** If the honest answer is "my own posts and people I already know", test that before you spend on ads.
>
> **Publish one cost number.** Shlomo showed the model costs and the profit. If you sell something that runs AI on every use, work out your cost per customer before you grow.
>
> **Plan for the day you stop being solo.** Decide what you will give away, hire or automate when the load becomes too much, and what you'll keep.
>
> **Read the deal, not the headline.** If you ever sell, ask for the split between cash at closing, deferred payments and performance payments in writing.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

Costs. AI products pay a cost every time a customer uses them. Base44 started 2026 with near-zero gross margin by Wix's own account, and the target of 60 percent depends on its own model.

Competition. Lovable, Replit, Bolt, Vercel and others are heavily funded and moving fast, and Wix has its own tools.

The headline. "$80 million in six months" omits the earn-out, the retention costs and the team of six to eight. It is a great result, and a more ordinary one than "solo founder, instant exit" suggests.

Interviews. He is a Wix employee now, and anything he says may be shaped by that. We have not spoken to him.

The numbers we couldn't confirm. User counts conflict, the revenue figure is a single report, and the financial detail of the deal comes from a summary we couldn't verify. All are flagged above.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **The earn-out.** Whether the 2029 milestones are met, and what Wix reports as it goes.
2. **Margins.** Whether Base 1 and cost control bring gross margin to around 60 percent.
3. **Wix's own growth.** Base44 is meant to lift the whole company. Whether it does, and at what cost, is the real test of the deal.
4. **The founder.** Whether Shlomo stays at Wix, and what he builds next.

He was called up, came back, and built something in months. The most useful thing in this story isn't the number on the cheque. It's how little of the early work needed a team, and how much of the later work did.

That's File #009. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #010 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Wix's announcement and results, Calcalist Ctech, Remarkable Magazine and Lenny's Podcast. User, revenue and staff figures conflict between sources, and we say so. We have not spoken to Maor Shlomo. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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